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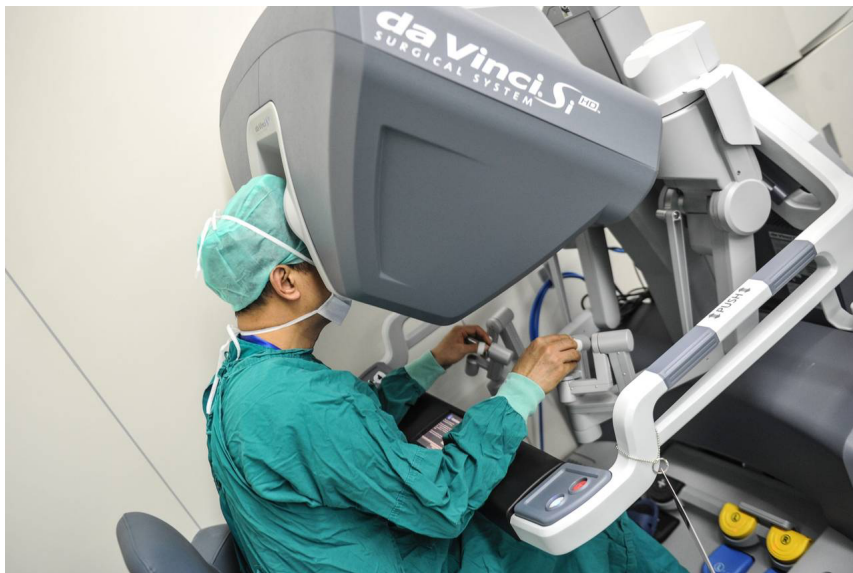
BUSINESS

Maker of Robotic-Assisted Surgical Systems Beats Profit Forecasts

Intuitive Surgical said its profit rose 41% in the fourth quarter

By Josh Beckerman

April 19, 2016 at 10:41 pm ET



Surgeons operate a da Vinci Surgical robot to remove a tumor last year at First Affiliated Hospital of Sun Yat-sen University in Guangzhou, Guangdong province of China. CHINAFOTOPRESS/GETTY IMAGES

Intuitive Surgical Inc. **ISRG 1.51%** ▲ said its profit rose 41% in the fourth quarter amid increased use of its robotic-assisted systems for minimally invasive surgery.

After the company reported results above Wall Street estimates, its shares rose 2.5% in late trading to \$639 apiece.

Intuitive Surgical said world-wide procedures using its da Vinci Surgical Systems rose nearly 17%, reflecting growth in U.S. general surgery and world-wide urologic

procedures. Shipments of the system increased to 110 from 99. The company has received U.S. and foreign regulatory approval for several new products in recent years.

In March, the U.S. Food and Drug Administration approved its 30-millimeter EndoWrist stapler products and its single-site instruments and accessories.

For the quarter ended March 31, Intuitive earned \$136.4 million, or \$3.54 a share, up from \$97 million, or \$2.57 a share, a year earlier. Earnings excluding items were \$4.42 a share. Revenue rose 12% to \$594.5 million.

Analysts polled by Thomson Reuters expected earnings excluding items of \$4.33 a share on revenue of \$592 million.

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Appeared in the April 20, 2016, print edition as 'Maker of Robotic-Assisted Surgical Systems Beats Profit Forecasts'.

